

decongestant. Its astringent properties make it a useful herb for the treatment of diarrhea and gastroenteritis.

Research Russian research indicates that lady's mantle reduces blood viscosity.

Caution Do not use lady's mantle when pregnant.

Aletris farinosa (Liliaceae)

Star Grass, True Unicorn Root, Colic Root

Description Perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has a flowering stem, smooth lance-shaped leaves, and white bell-shaped flowers that appear to be covered with frost.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to eastern North America, star grass grows mainly in swamps and wet sandy woodland, especially near the seashore. It is harvested commercially in Virginia, Tennessee, and North Carolina.

Parts Used Rhizome, leaves.

Constituents Star grass contains steroidal saponins based on diosgenin, as well as a bitter principle, volatile oil, and a resin.

History & Folklore The Native North American Catawba used a cold-water infusion of star grass leaves for stomachache. Star grass was also advocated for snake bite.

Medicinal Actions & Uses It is difficult to gain a clear picture of star grass's medicinal value. Due to its estrogenic action, it is employed chiefly for gynecological problems, particularly at menopause. It is also given for period pain and irregular periods. Some authorities hold that it prevents threatened miscarriage. Star grass is also a good digestive herb, proving beneficial in treating loss of appetite, indigestion, flatulence, and bloating.

⚠ **Cautions** Use only under professional supervision. The dried, and especially the fresh, rhizome can be toxic when taken in overdose, causing colic, diarrhea, and vomiting.

Allium cepa (Liliaceae)

Onion

Description Bulbous perennial growing to 3 ft (1 m). Has hollow stems and leaves, and white or purple flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to the northern hemisphere, onion has been cultivated in the Middle East for millennia. It is now grown worldwide as a vegetable.

Part Used Bulb.

Constituents Onion contains a volatile oil with sulphur-containing compounds such as allicin (an antibiotic) and alliin, flavonoids, phenolic acids, and sterols.

History & Folklore Authorities throughout the ancient world recommended onion for a variety of health problems. Bunches were hung on doors to ward off the plague in medieval Europe. Wild onion (*A. sibiricum*) was also used extensively by Native North Americans to treat stings and help relieve colds.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Onion boasts a long list of medicinal actions—diuretic, antibiotic, anti-inflammatory, analgesic, expectorant, and antirheumatic. It is also beneficial to the circulation. Onions are taken the world over for colds, flu, and coughs, much like garlic (*A. sativum*, p. 59). Onion offsets tendencies to angina, arteriosclerosis, and heart attack. It is also useful in preventing oral infection and tooth decay. The warmed juice can be dropped into the ear for earache, and baked onion is used as a poultice to drain pus from sores. Onion has a longstanding reputation as an aphrodisiac, and it is also used cosmetically to stimulate hair growth.



Onion juice is mixed with honey as a remedy for colds.

Related Species In Chinese herbal medicine, the scallion (*A. fistulosum*) is given to encourage sweating, to unblock the nose, and to relieve bloating. It is also used to help drain boils and abscesses.

Self-help Use Mild fever, p. 311.

Allium ursinum (Liliaceae)

Ramsons

Description Bulbous perennial smelling strongly of garlic, growing to 11 in (28 cm). Has a triangular stem and broad elliptical leaves. Clusters of white, star-like flowers grow from a common stem.

Habitat & Cultivation Ramsons are native to Europe and Asia. They carpet shady sites in damp woods and by streams. The plants are gathered in early summer.

Parts Used Bulb, aerial parts.

Constituents Ramsons contain volatile oil, aldehydes, vinyl sulfide, and vitamin C.

History & Folklore Ramsons (and many other onion-like plants) have been highly regarded as preventative medicines, as an old English rhyme attests: "Eat leeks in Lide and ramsons in May/And all the year after physicians may play!" More prosaically, Gerard (1597) wrote that the leaves "maye very well be eaten in April and Maie with butter [by those of] a strong constitution."

Medicinal Actions & Uses Used mainly as a folk remedy and as a food, ramsons are similar to garlic (*A. sativum*, p. 59) but weaker in action. They lower high blood pressure and help to prevent arteriosclerosis. As ramsons ease stomach pain and are tonic to the digestion, they have been used for diarrhea, colic, gas, indigestion, and loss of appetite. The whole herb is used in an infusion against threadworms, either ingested or given as an enema. Ramsons are also thought to be beneficial for asthma, bronchitis, and emphysema. The juice is used as an aid to weight loss.

Alnus glutinosa

syn. *A. rotundifolia* (Betulaceae)

Alder

Description Small tree with fissured bark, growing to 65 ft (20 m). Has notched oval leaves and male and female catkins.

Habitat & Cultivation Alder is native to Europe, Asia, and North Africa. It thrives in damp places and along riverbanks. The bark and leaves are gathered in spring.

Parts Used Bark, leaves.

Constituents Alder contains lignans, tannin (10–20%), emodin (an anthraquinone), and glycosides.